

LEGAL RECORDS INDEX & RETRIEVAL LOG

Work sample prepared by Peace Obisike

Sample prepared with invented facts. No client information.

WHAT THIS IS

A working records system for a single personal injury matter. It does three jobs:

- 1. Tells you every document that exists in the file, and where it is stored.
- 2. Tells you who asked for a document, when it went out, and whether it came back.
- 3. Proves each record was checked for accuracy before it was marked filed.

HOW TO USE IT

- Document Index One row per document. Add a new row every time a document arrives.
- Retrieval Log One row per request. Add a row every time a document leaves the file.
- Naming Convention The rule for naming every file. Follow it exactly, no exceptions.
- QC Checklist Run this before a document's status is changed to Filed.

Cells shaded yellow are the ones you type into. Everything else calculates itself.

MATTER SUMMARY (sample matter)

Matter name	Alvarez v. Rutherford Transit, Inc.
Matter number	PI-2026-0184
Client	Maria Alvarez
Matter type	Personal Injury - Motor Vehicle
Date opened	2026-03-11
Responsible attorney	[Attorney name]
Records custodian	Peace Obisike

FILE STATISTICS (calculated)

Total documents indexed	15
Total pages	235
Medical records	3
Medical bills	3
Correspondence	2
Pleadings	2

Documents awaiting QC	2
Documents filed	13
Items currently out of file	2

DOCUMENT INDEX - Alvarez v. Rutherford Transit, Inc. (PI-2026-0184)

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Add one row per document. Yellow columns are typed; keep Document Type spelled exactly as listed in the Naming Convention tab.

Doc ID	Date Received	Document Date	Document Type	Description	Source / From	Pages	Bates Range	File Name	Storage Path	Confidential	Retention Until	QC By	QC Date	Status
D-0001	2026-03-11	2026-02-27	Incident Report	California Highway Patrol traffic collision report, incident 26-04471	California Highway Patrol	14	ALV-000001-000014	2026-02-27_IncidentReport_CHP_D-0001.pdf	/Alvarez_Pi-2026-0184/01_Incident	No	2033-03-11	PO	2026-03-12	Filed
D-0002	2026-03-11	2026-03-11	Retainer Agreement	Signed contingency fee agreement, client and firm	Client	6	ALV-000015-000020	2026-03-11_RetainerAgreement_Alvarez_D-0002.pdf	/Alvarez_Pi-2026-0184/02_Engagement	Yes	2036-03-11	PO	2026-03-12	Filed
D-0003	2026-03-14	2026-02-27	Medical Record	Emergency department records, date of service 2026-02-27	Scripps Memorial Hospital	68	ALV-000021-000088	2026-02-27_MedicalRecord_ScrippsMemorial_D-0003.pdf	/Alvarez_Pi-2026-0184/03_Medical/Records	Yes	2036-03-14	PO	2026-03-16	Filed
D-0004	2026-03-14	2026-02-27	Medical Bill	Emergency department itemized billing statement	Scripps Memorial Hospital	9	ALV-000089-000097	2026-02-27_MedicalBill_ScrippsMemorial_D-0004.pdf	/Alvarez_Pi-2026-0184/03_Medical/Bills	Yes	2036-03-14	PO	2026-03-16	Filed
D-0005	2026-03-19	2026-03-18	Correspondence	Letter of representation to defendant carrier	Firm - outgoing	2	ALV-000098-000099	2026-03-18_Correspondence_OutgoingLOR_D-0005.pdf	/Alvarez_Pi-2026-0184/04_Correspondence	No	2033-03-19	PO	2026-03-19	Filed
D-0006	2026-04-02	2026-03-30	Insurance Document	Defendant carrier acknowledgment and claim number assignment	Meridian Mutual Insurance	3	ALV-000100-000102	2026-03-30_InsuranceDocument_MeridianMutual_D-0006.pdf	/Alvarez_Pi-2026-0184/05_Insurance	No	2033-04-02	PO	2026-04-03	Filed
D-0007	2026-04-21	2026-04-15	Medical Record	Physical therapy notes, 12 sessions, 2026-03-09 to 2026-04-15	Coastline Physical Therapy	41	ALV-000103-000143	2026-04-15_MedicalRecord_CoastlinePT_D-0007.pdf	/Alvarez_Pi-2026-0184/03_Medical/Records	Yes	2036-04-21	PO	2026-04-22	Filed
D-0008	2026-04-21	2026-04-15	Medical Bill	Physical therapy billing ledger	Coastline Physical Therapy	5	ALV-000144-000148	2026-04-15_MedicalBill_CoastlinePT_D-0008.pdf	/Alvarez_Pi-2026-0184/03_Medical/Bills	Yes	2036-04-21	PO	2026-04-22	Filed
D-0009	2026-05-06	2026-05-04	Employment Record	Wage and time records establishing lost earnings	Del Sur Unified School District	17	ALV-000149-000165	2026-05-04_EmploymentRecord_DelSurUSD_D-0009.pdf	/Alvarez_Pi-2026-0184/06_Damages	Yes	2036-05-06	PO	2026-05-07	Filed
D-0010	2026-05-28	2026-05-26	Pleading	Complaint for damages, filed San Diego County Superior Court	Firm - outgoing	11	ALV-000166-000176	2026-05-26_Pleading_ComplaintForDamages_D-0010.pdf	/Alvarez_Pi-2026-0184/07_Pleadings	No	2036-05-28	PO	2026-05-28	Filed
D-0011	2026-06-18	2026-06-16	Pleading	Defendant answer to complaint	Opposing counsel	8	ALV-000177-000184	2026-06-16_Pleading_DefendantAnswer_D-0011.pdf	/Alvarez_Pi-2026-0184/07_Pleadings	No	2036-06-18	PO	2026-06-19	Filed
D-0012	2026-07-09	2026-07-07	Discovery	Plaintiff responses to form interrogatories, set one	Firm - outgoing	23	ALV-000185-000207	2026-07-07_Discovery_PltfRespFormRogsSet1_D-0012.pdf	/Alvarez_Pi-2026-0184/08_Discovery	Yes	2036-07-09	PO	2026-07-10	Filed
D-0013	2026-08-25	2026-08-20	Medical Record	Orthopedic consultation and MRI report	Pacific Orthopedic Associates	22	ALV-000208-000229	2026-08-20_MedicalRecord_PacificOrtho_D-0013.pdf	/Alvarez_Pi-2026-0184/03_Medical/Records	Yes	2036-08-25	PO	2026-08-26	Filed
D-0014	2026-09-08	2026-09-04	Correspondence	Records request follow-up to imaging provider	Firm - outgoing	2	ALV-000230-000231	2026-09-04_Correspondence_OutgoingRecordsRequest_D-0014.pdf	/Alvarez_Pi-2026-0184/04_Correspondence	No	2033-09-08			Pending QC
D-0015	2026-09-11	2026-09-10	Medical Bill	Orthopedic consultation and imaging charges	Pacific Orthopedic Associates	4	ALV-000232-000235	2026-09-10_MedicalBill_PacificOrtho_D-0015.pdf	/Alvarez_Pi-2026-0184/03_Medical/Bills	Yes	2036-09-11			Pending QC

TOTAL235

Retention rule applied in this sample: general litigation file 7 years from close; records containing protected health information 10 years. Confirm against the firm's own retention schedule before use.

RETRIEVAL LOG - who asked for what, when it left, when it came back

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Request Date	Doc ID	Document Requested	Requested By	Purpose	Date Returned / Closed	Status	Notes
2026-05-20	D-0003	Emergency department records	Attorney	Drafting complaint	2026-05-21	Returned	Returned same business day
2026-06-02	D-0004	Emergency department billing statement	Paralegal	Special damages calculation	2026-06-02	Returned	
2026-07-01	D-0009	Wage and time records	Attorney	Lost earnings analysis	2026-07-03	Returned	
2026-08-27	D-0013	Orthopedic consultation and MRI report	Attorney	Demand package preparation		Outstanding	Follow up scheduled 2026-09-15
2026-09-09	D-0007	Physical therapy notes	Paralegal	Demand package preparation		Outstanding	Copy provided, original retained

Rule: nothing leaves the file without a row in this log. An item still Outstanding after 5 business days is chased in writing.

FILE NAMING CONVENTION

THE RULE

YYYY-MM-DD_DocumentType_Source_DocID.pdf

Worked example

2026-02-27_MedicalRecord_ScrippsMemorial_D-0003.pdf

Part 1 - Date

Date ON the document, not the day it arrived. Always YYYY-MM-DD so files sort in date order automatically.

Part 2 - Document Type

One of the approved types listed below. No new types without the records custodian approving it.

Part 3 - Source

Who produced it. No spaces; join words (ScrippsMemorial, CoastlinePT). Use 'OutgoingLOR' style for firm-produced documents.

Part 4 - Doc ID

The unique ID from the Document Index. Never reused, never renumbered.

NEVER DO THIS

Spaces, commas, apostrophes, &, /, #, %. Use no punctuation except the underscore and the hyphens in the date.

Names like final.pdf, scan1.pdf, new version.pdf, Untitled.pdf, or a client's name alone.

Two files with the same name. If a document is replaced, the old one moves to /99_Superseded and keeps its original name.

APPROVED DOCUMENT TYPES

Incident Report

Police reports, collision reports, accident reports, scene documentation

Retainer Agreement

Fee agreements, engagement letters, scope amendments

Medical Record

Clinical notes, imaging reports, hospital records, therapy notes

Medical Bill

Itemized statements, billing ledgers, liens, explanation of benefits

Correspondence

Letters and formal emails in or out

Insurance Document

Policy documents, claim acknowledgments, coverage letters, adjuster correspondence

Employment Record

Wage records, time records, employer statements, lost earnings proof

Pleading

Complaints, answers, motions, court orders, notices

Discovery

Interrogatories, requests for production, responses, deposition transcripts

Authorization

HIPAA authorizations, records release forms, signed consents

Expert Material

Expert reports, CVs, retention letters

Internal Note

Case memos, call notes, internal summaries

FOLDER STRUCTURE

/01_Incident
/02_Engagement
/03_Medical/Records
/03_Medical/Bills
/04_Correspondence
/05_Insurance
/06_Damages
/07_Pleadings
/08_Discovery
/09_Experts
/10_Internal
/99_Superseded

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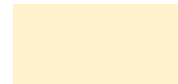
RECORDS QUALITY CONTROL CHECKLIST

Run every line before a document's status changes from Pending QC to Filed. One unchecked line means the document is not filed.

#	Check	Pass / Fail	If it fails, do this
1	Every page of the document is present and in order. Page count matches the Pages column.		Request a complete copy from the source before doing anything else.
2	Every page is readable. No cut-off text, no black bars, no upside-down or sideways pages.		Rescan or re-request. Do not file an unreadable record.
3	The document actually belongs to this matter. Client name and date of incident match.		Stop. Do not file. Report to the supervising attorney the same day.
4	The file name follows the naming convention exactly.		Rename before filing. Update the Document Index.
5	The document is saved in the correct folder for its type.		Move it. Update the Storage Path column.
6	The Document Index row is complete. No blank cells except QC By and QC Date.		Complete the row.
7	The date entered is the date on the document, not the date it arrived.		Correct the Document Date column.
8	This is not a duplicate of a document already indexed.		Move the duplicate to /99_Superseded. Do not give it a new Doc ID.
9	If the document replaces an earlier version, the earlier version has been moved to /99_Superseded.		Move it and note the replacement in the Notes column.
10	The document has been searchable-text processed (OCR) if it was a scan.		Run OCR before filing.
11	Confidential flag is set correctly. Anything with medical or financial content is marked Yes.		Correct the flag and check folder permissions.
12	Retention Until date is calculated from the firm's retention schedule.		Calculate and enter it.
13	Bates range does not overlap any range already used in this matter.		Renumber. Overlapping Bates numbers cause real problems at deposition.
14	A backup copy exists in the firm's cloud storage, not only on a local machine.		Upload before marking the record filed.

Checked by:

Date:



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